

Civil disobedience



It almost goes without saying that individuals often disagree with the policies of their governments – especially if that government is tyrannical or an exploitative colonial power. But what if the individual considers the state's actions morally wrong? The transcendentalist Henry Thoreau (see [Transcendentalism](#)) believed that laws suppress rather than protect the civil liberties of the citizen, and saw it as a citizen's right to resist any laws to which he or she had a conscientious objection. He advocated peaceful resistance through non-cooperation – in his own case the non-payment of taxes that would support the slave trade and the war in Mexico. To

passively permit laws and government policies that are against our moral beliefs is to effectively validate them, so it is not only our right but our duty to resist them. Thoreau's idea of the moral rightness of civil disobedience on the grounds of conscience, and especially the use of non-violent resistance, was adopted successfully by Gandhi in the fight for Indian independence, and by Martin Luther King in the struggle for civil rights in the United States.